LAUNCH PAD · A GUIDE'S LESSON PLAN BOOK

The Forge Year

What is worth solving?

A guide's book for Year Two of the Launch Pad, written so a learner can read every page.

VIBRANT LIFE

THE YEAR AT A GLANCE

Part 1 - For everyone: what this year is

Part 2 - For the guide: teaching this year

Part 3 - The sessions

1 Naming the Dragon (four weeks, Aug 14 - Sep 7)

2 The Detective (five weeks, Sep 18 - Oct 19)

3 My Arena (three weeks, Oct 30 - Nov 16, ends into Thanksgiving)

4 The Wider Field (three weeks, Nov 27 - Dec 14, ends into the winter break)

5 The Long Game (six weeks, Jan 1 - Feb 8)

6 Hands to Work (six weeks, Feb 19 - Mar 29)

7 The Call to Action (four weeks, Apr 9 - May 3, the year's harvest)

Part 4 - Closing the year

A note before you begin

This book is the plan for The Forge - the second of the three Launch Pad years. It is written for the guide who runs the year, and it is written so that any learner can pick it up and read the whole thing. There is nothing hidden in here.

Here is the rule, and it holds on every page: everything in this book is safe and honest for a learner to read. Nothing in it manages or manipulates anyone. Lines in "quotes" are things a guide might say aloud. Everything else is for the guide to understand and hold - the reasons behind the moves, the care points, the things to watch for. A learner who reads a guide's note will find an adult thinking carefully and kindly about how to be useful, never an adult figuring out how to steer them.

If you are a learner reading this: welcome. This is your year, and you are allowed to see how it was built. At the end of the year you will be invited to help rebuild it for the next group, and you can say no to that too.

One author's note on language: this book was written by Erin Stanley, who opened the studio and guided its first year. "The guide" means whoever is leading the studio, and this book says "they" throughout, because that will not always be the same person. Where the book says the guide is raising a small child, that is the shape of the year it was written for, named so the shape is owned; a later guide names their own shape in the same place. "You" sometimes means the guide and sometimes means the learner - the context always makes it clear which.

Part 1 - For everyone: what this year is

The year's question

The Forge asks one thing, all year: **What is worth solving?**

The first year, Origin, was about dreaming your life and figuring out who you are. This year is about building: turning your gaze outward, from yourself to the world and the problems in it. You will find a real problem that matters to you, trace it down to its root, and act on it alongside the people who actually have it.

The anchor line for the year is simple: **things are only impossible until they're not.**

The three years each carry their own question:

- **Origin - Who am I?** (Know your story.)
- **The Forge - What is worth solving?** (Find your work.)
- **The Helm - What do I do when there is no easy answer?** (Make the hard call, and love the life around it.)

The three years turn as a cycle rather than a ladder. Whichever year is running when you arrive is the one you start in, and you are not behind. A learner who starts here asks what is worth solving with the story they already have, and comes to Origin later with more of it. Nobody here is catching up to anybody. There is a short note for learners starting here at the end of this Part.

The journey (the year's arc, plain)

Here is the shape of the whole year, in order:

1. **Name a real problem.** Learn the difference between a problem you can act on and a thing you just have to accept. Name your problem so precisely that it stops being a fog and becomes a thing you can actually work on.

2. **Trace it to its root.** The obvious villain is almost never the real cause. You will learn to keep asking "why" until you hit the system underneath, and to ask who is still answerable inside that system, including, sometimes, you.
3. **Find your arena.** Not every problem is yours to move. You will find the slice of it where your own action actually changes something, and try to move one small thing.
4. **Lift your eyes to the world.** You will go out and meet real problems where they live, and choose the one that gets to you. Not the one you think you should care about. The one that actually moves you.
5. **Play the long game.** Big problems are systems, not single heroic acts. You will break the impossible into a next doable step, find the real lever, and gather people.
6. **Put your hands to work.** You will act, for real, with real people, designing the work *with* them, never *for* them.
7. **Tell a room what's worth solving.** You will make the case: here is a problem worth solving, here is why it got to me, here is what I did, here is what I ask of you.

The three years together move like this: first you look at yourself, then you look at the world, and in the final year you learn to make the hard call when there is no easy answer. This is the middle year. The turn outward.

The words this book uses

This studio has its own small vocabulary. None of it is a secret, so here it all is, before you meet any of it.

- **A quest.** One piece of work with a beginning and an end: a prompt, an interview, a making, a share. It is the unit you can say no to.
- **A session.** One of the year's seven stretches, each with its own question. Three to six weeks long, with a break after it.
- **Core.** Short for your core academics: the high-school credit work you have claimed, at your own pace, on your own days.
- **The settle.** The three slow breaths that open every guide day.
- **The way down.** Standing up and shaking it out after hard work, so your body can put the stress down.
- **The exit ramp.** The named place you can step out to, without asking, and come back from with nothing said.

- **The close-return.** The words the room says out loud after a heavy day, so your body hears that the heavy part is over. Always the same words; they are on the settle page.
- **The closing minute.** The three private questions at the end of an opening. Never written for the studio, never read by anyone.
- **The Captain's Log.** Your own record of your own life. Yours.
- **The Vineyard.** The thing you love that nobody ever makes useful.
- **The Work of the Day.** The one piece of the session's work the whole tribe does together that morning, named out loud at the start so you know what the day is for.
- **Your tribe.** The people in this studio with you.
- **The walk-in.** Two things share this word. The walk-in is the soft first stretch of a guide day, when the door is open and nothing is required. It is also what we call the quiet one-to-one conversations that happen inside that window, where the guide comes to one or two people rather than calling anyone over. "I'll catch you in the walk-in" means a conversation, not a meeting, and nothing in it is written down.
- **Fallow.** Deliberately empty. Fallow is a farming word: a fallow field is one you leave unplanted on purpose, because that is what makes it rich again. Fridays are fallow, and so is one whole week in the autumn. Never earned, never filled.
- **A harvest.** The last stretch of a session, where you gather what the weeks grew and name what you got. It is yours to gather, and an empty harvest is a real harvest.
- **Witnessed.** Someone was there and saw it. Not watched, not assessed. Being witnessed is a gift and never a demand.
- **A re-thread.** Picking the year back up after a break. The first guide day back starts with it: where were you, where are you now, what came back changed. You are never restarting cold.
- **The pace question.** The guide asking whether the plan still matches the speed your real life is running at.
- **The re-ask.** The guide asking, out loud, *is this still yours?* It is not a mood check and it is not rhetorical. "No" and "I don't know" are both real answers, and it gets asked at points in the year where there is still time to act on the answer.
- **The Impossible Question.** The question with no clean answer that opens every guide day, after the settle and the circle, argued for fun. "Could we end loneliness?" Nobody is meant to answer it. It is practice at standing inside something too big to close.

- **Your dragon.** The one problem you carry all year, named precisely enough to work on. "Everything sucks" is not a dragon. "Nobody my age in this town has anywhere to be on a Friday night" is.
- **A fact of life.** A hard thing you cannot act on and have to accept. Fighting one wears you out and tells you it was your fault.
- **How-Might-We.** A complaint turned into a question with a door in it. "History is pointless" becomes "how might we make it matter?"
- **The Iceberg.** The problem you can see on top, and the bigger thing underneath that it sits on.
- **The 5 Whys.** Ask "why?" of a problem, then "why?" of the answer, about five times, until you reach the bottom. Run it more than once; most problems have more than one root.
- **The Three Circles.** Three rings for sorting your worries: what you can control, what you can influence, what you can only be concerned about.
- **Your arena.** The slice of your problem where your own action moves something. A small arena is not a small person.
- **A starter quest.** One small real problem inside your arena that you can finish, so you have moved something before the big one.
- **The Commons Problem.** One problem the whole tribe argues into choosing together and carries as a "we." It gets its own talk at the end of the year, given by everyone at once; we call that talk the chorus.
- **The relay.** You are one hand in a relay that began before you and goes on after you. Carry it your distance and pass it well. Nobody is asked to solve it alone.
- **A lever, and the ladder of levers.** A lever is where a small push moves a lot. The ladder: change a number, change a rule or who enforces it, change the goal, change the story everyone believes. The obvious levers are usually the weakest.
- **The shadow of the problem.** The uncomfortable truth inside a problem that nobody wants to say, which is usually why it stays unsolved. We look at the shadow of the problem, never the shadow of you.
- **The Call to Action.** The talk you may give at year's end: here is a problem worth solving, why it got to me, what I did, what I ask of you. It is the harvest, and it is a feast, not a judged presentation.
- **A Call to Repair.** The other shape the talk takes when the honest finding is that something went wrong: here is what I owe, who leads this, how you join them. A whole talk, not a lesser one.

- **Open Waters.** The loose three weeks after the Call to Action: expeditions, your own projects, credit close-out, and real rest.
- **The short Origin.** If you are joining this year, the small version of the first year's three things, built in your own work time across the first four weeks. Nobody grades it and nobody can see who is doing it.

What you make and carry

The Captain's Log. You have one artifact that travels with you across all three years: your Captain's Log. It is a record of your own life and your own thinking. You name it yourself. You write in it however you write. It belongs to you, completely. A guide never reads it to grade you or check up on you. The moment a private log becomes something someone else reads to judge you, it stops being yours, and this one stays yours. You will carry it out the door when you leave, and no copy is kept, because the moment there is a copy somebody else is holding your life.

If you are joining this year, your Log starts now, on your first day, the same first page everyone else started with. Every Log starts empty. Yours starts now.

The Vineyard. Alongside the Log runs a second thread called the Vineyard. It was named on your first day here, whichever year that was, on the same morning the Captain's Log was named. The two are twins. The Log is the self examined; the Vineyard is the self delighted. The Vineyard is whatever you tend purely because you love it, for no useful reason at all: a garden, a song you are learning, a craft, a friendship, a wandering, a game, an album on the floor. Nobody harvests it. Nobody asks you to write a reflection on it. Nobody makes it count for anything. The instant someone tries to make the Vineyard *useful*, it dies, which is why the rule protecting it is written as hard as the rules about safety. It is here because the whole point of these three years is to make the hard call **and still love your life**, and that half of the thing cannot wait for the last year. If you are joining this year, you name your own Vineyard-thing in the first week, too.

When, and this is the one part that is required. Making time for something you love is a requirement of this programme. Not a particular thing, not a certain number of hours, and not anything you hand in. The requirement is that the time is in your week and that something you love is in the time. Friday is already yours and is the obvious home. Nobody ever checks what you did with the time. The only question anyone will ever ask is *is the time there.* The requirement binds us to keep making room for it. It does not bind you to fill the room.

The promises (the six refusals)

Underneath everything, there is a floor of promises. Nothing in the Launch Pad is allowed to break these. In plain words:

1. **No grades or scores anyone but you can see.** Your progress is yours. High-school credit is the one honest exception, and it is explained at the end of this Part.
2. **No ranking and no leaderboards.** You are never stacked against the person next to you. A parent linked to your account can see which of your own goals you have finished, and that is the whole of what anyone else sees. If that ever stops being exactly true, you will be told before it changes, not after.
3. **No one deposits the answers into you.** You make meaning here; the guide holds questions and walks with you, and does not hand you a finished answer.
4. **No imposed deadlines.** You set your own pace. "I didn't get to it" is honored, not punished.
5. **Your worth is not your output.** A quest you abandoned and learned from counts as much as one you finished. Doing more does not make you worth more.
6. **No surveillance.** The data of your life belongs to you, not to the school. This promise is about a short list of what gets written down about you, and the list is at the end of this Part so you can check it.

And one more, which sits on top of the six:

You may refuse the structure itself. If you decline a whole quest, you are fully honored. You are not quietly marked down as a failure or an opt-out. Your no is real.

Where your no reaches, and where it stops

Here is the edge of that last promise, said now rather than discovered later.

Your no covers your own work. A quest, a prompt, an expedition, a share, a whole session, this entire structure. It lands the moment you say it, it costs you nothing, and nobody can overrule it.

It does not cover how you treat the people in the room with you. That is not a deadline and it is not output. It is the floor that makes everything else here safe for the other people in the room, and it is the one place in this programme where something can actually be taken from you. The studio's agreements run that floor, and they have their own ladder: a Pause, then a Stop, then a Strike. You will meet it in your first week, and you will help write the agreements it rests on. The count clears at the start of every year, so nothing from last year walks in with you.

So, in one line: **the agreements are about how we treat each other. The promises are about whether you do the work.**

Declining a quest is never a Pause. A Pause is never a judgement on your work, your pace, or whether you are keeping up. If anyone ever runs those two together, they have got it wrong, and you can say so out loud and point at this page.

And if you do not sign. You are in the room anyway, and that was never the price of being here. The agreements still run for you, and here is the honest reason rather than a convenient one: they are not holding you to your word, because you did not give it. They are holding the room safe for the people in it with you. You can tell us the agreements are not yours. You cannot be outside the floor, because **the floor is not about you.**

How we work: the week

The studio day runs through the morning, 9:00 to 1:00. Across the week, two mornings are guide days and two are your own.

- **Guide days (Tuesday and Thursday).** The guide runs the studio with you. The order of the morning is below, and it is the same every time. What differs this year is the middle: Tuesday's work is lighter, and Thursday holds the week's one deep block. That is on purpose. The guide is running the studio solo in a week that is otherwise parenting a toddler, with childcare for the two guide mornings and no more, and chose the shape that holds rather than the shape that looks fuller, and says so out loud. Choosing the sustainable shape and naming it is itself part of what this place teaches.
- **Your-own days (Monday and Wednesday).** You run your own morning: your reading, your core academics, your personal project, and the session's writing. Nobody is steering but you. This year the guide is not in the building on your own days: they have left Vibrant Life Tots and are at home with their child on the mornings they are not with you. Who is in the building on those mornings, and how the midday check-in happens, is not settled yet; it will be written here, plainly, before any family is handed this book, because a learner should never find out on a Monday who is and is not down the hall.
- **The fallow day (Friday).** Protected. Never earned, never filled, never converted back into work. It is for rest, play, friendship, and making things for no reason. This is not a reward for finishing. It is practice for a whole life. And it is binding: it does not get eaten to cover a busy week. It is for you and for the guide both.

A guided morning, start to finish

Guide days run 9:00 to 1:00. The order is the same on both days, so you never walk in wondering what today is. What changes between Tuesday and Thursday is the middle block.

Time	What happens
9:00 - 9:25	**The walk-in.** Door open, nothing required. Put your things down, make tea, talk or don't. The guide is here and will come find one or two people for a quiet one-to-one.
9:25 - 9:35	**The settle, then the circle.** Three breaths, the same words every time. Then one round of "how are you, really?" You may pass.
9:35 - 10:50	**The Work of the Day.** Tuesday: the Impossible Question, then the lighter work - a game, a group challenge, hands-on building, planning an expedition. Thursday: the week's one deep block. This is the part that changes week to week. The rest of this table does not.
10:50 - 11:00	**The way down.** Stand, shake it out, step outside, water. Then we eat.
11:00 - 11:40	**The Table.** We eat together. You bring your own lunch.
11:40 - 12:40	**Hands and each other.** Making, building, service prep, an errand into the world, a project with somebody else. Different from the morning's work on purpose: the body works and the talking gets easy.
12:40 - 1:00	**The close.** One light thing, then your closing minute, then you go.

The times are honest rather than strict. Most days drift ten minutes. The order never drifts.

Expedition Tuesdays leave the building (Session 4's second week, and the service weeks of Session 6), so the grid bends: the guide tells you the day before where we gather, when we go, and when we are back. The walk-in, the Table and the close still happen; they happen where we are.

The Table

Every guide day has a shared meal in the middle of it. Here is exactly how it goes.

You bring your own lunch. On ordinary days the studio does not provide the food.

It is still a shared table rather than a lunch break. We stop, sit down together, and the guide sits and eats with you. The forty minutes is for being a group of people who eat together, not for getting through food on the way to the next thing.

You sit wherever you want. Seats are not assigned, and nobody's seat is kept from last week.

You do not have to eat. Presence is the whole requirement here, never consumption. If you are fasting, or observing, or not hungry, or food is a hard thing for you right now, you sit with us and that is full participation. Nobody watches anybody's plate, and you never owe anyone an explanation for what is or is not on yours.

If you arrive late, come in and sit down. Nothing restarts, and nobody asks where you were in front of the room.

On the one day a year when there *is* shared food, the feast after the Call to Action in the last week, tell the guide what you cannot eat, once, whenever you know it. Planning around it is the guide's job rather than yours to work around. That day the studio provides the base of the meal, and bringing a dish is never required. If you want what the studio brings to stand as yours, say so to the guide once, privately, and it will. Nobody at the table will know the difference, and nobody will ask.

On an expedition your lunch travels with you, the same as any guide day, and the guide says the day before where we eat and when. If the place we visit serves food to people who need it, that food is theirs. We eat what we brought, where the host says, or after we leave. Being a guest is part of what the expedition teaches.

The circle: "how are you, really?"

Right after the settle, every guide day, we go around once. The question is "how are you, really?" and it means the real answer rather than the automatic one.

Here is how it goes. The guide asks, and answers first, honestly and briefly. Then it goes around in order, so nobody is picked on and nobody has to volunteer. One or two sentences each is plenty. "Tired." "Good, actually." "I don't want to say today." Those are complete answers.

You can always pass. Say "pass" and it moves on, with no follow-up and no note taken. Passing is not a smaller answer. A person who passes has been round the circle the same as everyone else.

Nobody fixes what you say here unless you ask. Advice that arrives unasked is not help, so the circle starts from being heard.

But you can ask, and you can ask the room. "Does anyone know what to do about this?" is a completely normal thing to say in a circle, and so is "I just wanted to say it, I don't want to talk about it." Both are answers to the same question, and the question is yours: **do you want this held, or do you want it worked?** Say which and the room will follow you. Six people who know you is not a smaller resource than one guide, and some things a sixteen-year-old knows better than any adult in the building.

If you would rather not ask in front of everyone, that is equally fine. Say so, or say nothing and catch the guide afterwards.

It takes a few minutes. It is not a check-up, and nothing said in it is written down. Then the Impossible Question, which comes after the circle on purpose: you cannot stand inside something enormous while nobody in the room knows you are tired.

Who else is in the room

There are a handful of you and one of me. My child is not in the studio this year. On the two guide mornings they are with their childcare, arranged before the year opens, and the rest of the week I am with them; that is the honest shape of this year, and it is why the year runs two guide mornings and not more. The first year, my child was in the room with us, worn. This year you get all of me on the mornings I am here. If the childcare falls through on a guide morning, you will be told that morning what the day is: the deep block waits for the next guide day and the morning turns into hands and each other, or the morning is called off before anyone arrives. That is the design working, not a lost day, and you will be told which it is rather than left to guess. On expedition days the childcare covers the travel time too, and that is planned per outing.

One thing you should hear plainly. If you ever need all of me, a hard day or a conversation that cannot be interrupted, say so. On a guide morning there is nothing to hand off; you have me.

Arriving late, stepping out, coming back

Arriving late. Walk in. There is no procedure and nothing restarts. If the circle is going, join where it has got to, or pass. If the settle is going, sit down and pick it up on the next breath. Nobody will ask you in front of the room where you were. If something made you late and you want the guide to know, catch them at the Table. On an expedition Tuesday the group leaves the building, so if you are late and we have gone, call the number the guide gives you in the first week and we work out the honest option together. Nobody asks why in front of anyone.

Coming back after stepping out. The soft parts of the day are named so you know where the easiest way back in is: the walk-in, the Table, and the hands block after it. You can come back at any moment, including the middle of a hard one. The soft seams are just the ones where nothing has to be said at all. Nobody says anything to you when you come back. Not even "glad you're back." You pick up a plate or pick up a tool and you are in.

The Log, captured however you hold it

You keep the Captain's Log in whatever form is true to you. Written in a notebook. Spoken aloud and recorded. Drawn. Dictated. Typed. Told to a scribe who writes it down for you. No form is the lesser Log. The point is that you are keeping your own record, not that it looks a certain way.

Where it lives. Your Log can go home with you, or stay here somewhere only you open, or both, and you can change your mind any time. If you want it to stay here, say so and nobody asks why. It is not kept in the Compass or on any school computer, and no copy is made, because the moment there is a copy somebody else is holding your life.

When you write in it. There is no Log time and nobody will ever call one. Here is where the room has room for it, and all of these are open rather than expected:

- **The walk-in**, the first twenty-five minutes of a guide day. Nothing is required then, so if you came in with something on your mind, that is the place to put it down before the day starts asking things of you.
- **Right after your closing minute**, at the end of a guide day. This is the natural one.
- **Your own mornings**, Monday and Wednesday. Your block, your call, no check-in about it. When the week's flow says "Log" on your own days, that is a place the day has room for it, never a thing anyone checks.
- **Friday**, if you want it. Friday is also a fine day to deliberately not write. A record you have to feed every day stops being a record and becomes a chore, and **there are supposed to be days**

you skip. Weeks, even. A Log with gaps in it is not a failed Log; it is what an honest one looks like.

One rule about this, and it is for the guide as much as you: **nobody writes on a bell.** We will never all sit down and write at the same time, because the moment that happens, everyone can see who is writing and who is not, and the only thing that makes this yours is that nobody is watching. Your Log is private in what it says and private in whether you touched it today.

How "no" works here

You may decline anything. **Your no takes effect the moment you say it, and it is not conditional on explaining yourself.** This is called **decline-with-reasoning**, and here is the honest shape of it.

You can say no to any quest, any prompt, any expedition, any share, and the no lands straight away. Nothing is held up while you find words.

The reasoning is still owed. Two things about that, and they matter equally. **It is owed to your tribe, not to the guide.** You are in a room with other people whose work and plans move around yours, so they get to know where you stand. It is not a toll you pay an adult for permission. And **it is not owed in the moment.** "I don't know yet, and I'll come back to you" is a real answer. Take a day. Take the week. Work it out in your Log first and come back when you have it. A reason you had to produce on the spot is not thinking, it is pressure.

The guide may ask you an honest, curious question about it, the way a friend might. But the guide **has a voice, never a veto.** The guide cannot overrule your reason, and cannot require you to have one ready. The question is a mirror, not a test you can fail.

There is one place where even the curious question is set aside: anything to do with official papers and government forms, which this year's life-admin work touches. There, an honest reason for declining might reveal something private about your legal situation that a guide has no business knowing. So on that one surface, your no needs no reason at all.

The settle

Every guide day opens with a short, body-first way in, and there is a matching way down when something gets heavy. This is fixed, and it is yours to keep for life.

- **The way in (the settle).** Three slow breaths with the out-breath longer than the in-breath (roughly four counts in, six counts out), feet flat, one hand where you feel your breath. The guide paces it out loud, the same way every time. The out-breath is what tells your body it is

safe to settle. No app, no playlist, no special frequency. Just a human voice, used the same way on purpose. It is the same three moves every day, all three years, because the sameness is what lets it become yours.

- **The way down.** After hard work stirs the body up, you stand, shake it out, take a short walk, move the activation *through* the body before sitting back down. If standing or walking is not yours, any movement that is - shaking out your hands, rolling your shoulders, rocking - does the same work. You cannot metabolize a stress spike sitting still. This is thirty seconds to a few minutes, and it comes before the shared meal, because an activated body cannot receive a meal as belonging.
- **The way out (the exit ramp).** There is a named place you can step out to, set up in the first week. You do not have to ask. And there is a designed way back in during a soft part of the day, with no scene, no acknowledgment demanded. Stepping out and coming back costs you nothing. This is the room holding a door open for you, never the room watching you for a fall.
- **The way back (the close-return).** After a day that went somewhere heavy, the room says out loud that the heavy part is over, so your body hears it and not just your head. These words do not change either:

  > SAY
  >
  > "That was then. This is now. Look around and name one thing you can see. You're in this room, and the hard part is behind you."

  It sounds almost too simple to do anything. It works because a body that has been inside a hard thing for an hour does not automatically notice that the hour ended, and being told, in words, is how it notices. Solo version, for the rest of your life: *that was then, this is now, and I'm here.*

The closing minute

At the close of an opening - a problem that got to you, a hard conversation, a look at the shadow of a problem - you take a quiet minute and cross back through three fixed questions. They are always the same, in the same order:

1. **What did I meet?**
2. **What do I carry back?**

3. **What's different in me now - even a little?**

That is the whole practice. It is spoken or held in your head, never written down for the studio, never read by anyone. It is yours. It runs at the close of every guide day, light days included, because a practice used only on heavy days never becomes the one you reach for at forty.

Reach for the real answer. Taking the first thing that comes to mind and moving on makes this worth almost nothing. Staying in the question for a whole minute and letting something come up makes it worth a great deal, and **something almost always comes up, if you stay open long enough to hear it.** That takes a kind of nerve. It is the same nerve the rest of this year asks for.

"I don't know yet" is a real answer, not because the question has no answer, but because sometimes the true one has not surfaced, and naming that beats manufacturing something to have said. "Nothing's different, and I'm steadier for having looked" is also true and complete, because steadier is a change.

But you will know the difference between *I don't know yet* and *I didn't look.* Nobody else ever will. Nobody reads this, nobody asks about it, and no one can tell from the outside whether you reached or shrugged. **This is the one practice here that runs entirely on your own honour**, and what you do with a quiet minute when nobody is checking is worth knowing about yourself.

The one adult outside the room

There is one adult, outside the studio, you can always talk to. You will know who they are and how to reach them in the first week, before you ever need them.

One honest line about breaks, said now. When the studio is on a break - the short ones between sessions, Thanksgiving, the two weeks at winter, and the summer - the guide is not reachable. A break is rest and reset for them too, and the book protects that the same way it protects your Friday. The one adult outside the room is reachable across every break, the same as always. And if you are ever in danger, or someone else is, **988** is free, open all day and all night, and you can call or text it from anywhere. Nobody here will ever be upset that you used it.

And this is the honest shape of privacy, said on the first day rather than saved for the moment it matters. Almost everything stays here. Your Captain's Log, nobody reads. Your closing minute is never written down by anyone.

Here is what doesn't. If the guide believes you are in danger, that someone is hurting or neglecting you, or that something is going on that is bigger than a studio morning can hold, they will bring in real help. That includes talk of suicide or self-harm, abuse or neglect, something

going wrong with eating, a crisis with drugs or alcohol, a panic or a flashback they cannot reach you through, a threat to someone else, or something that keeps going and is getting in the way of your life.

Those are two different things and they have different consequences, so both get named. **Abuse or neglect is a report**, and in Idaho the guide is required by law to make it. **Everything else on that list is a hand-off**, which means they stop the session work and help you get to someone trained, you will be told who, and you get a say in which one and when.

In most of those cases they will also call your parent or guardian, and they will tell you they are making the call. The one exception is if your parent or guardian is the person hurting you. Then the call goes to the state rather than to them.

That is the whole list. It is not one secret trapdoor, and the guide will never go looking for a reason to use it. **What they know is only what you chose to tell them.** None of this is breaking trust. It is what care actually looks like.

What gets written down about you

Short answer: very little, and you can read all of it.

- **Your Captain's Log and your Vineyard.** Yours. Nobody reads them. No copy is kept.
- **Your closing minute.** Never written down at all, by anyone.
- **Your witnessed work** - your named dragon, your plan and prototype, what you did with real people, your Call to Action. The guide sees what you bring into the room, and so do the people you choose to show. That is what bringing it means.
- **The guide's own notes.** A short practical record: attendance, your pace and your credit plan, and a factual note if there is ever a safety event, meaning what happened, what they did, and who they called. A safety note never contains what you wrote or said about your own life.
- **Your Growth Record, in the Compass.** The one record here that is built to leave with you. It works differently from everything else on this list, so it has its own section below.
- **The agreements record, if you ever reach a Stop.** Our studio agreements run on a ladder: a Pause, then a Stop, then a Strike. The Stop and the Strike are the two rungs that make paper. A Stop note says what happened and goes home the same day, you fill it out with your guide, and the line about coming back is yours in your own words. A Strike letter lists the dates of the three Stops. Your character contract is yours, in your handwriting, and a copy stays with Jenna, who runs the school, while you are working it. All of it records a choice and never a

judgement about who you are, the count clears at the start of each year, and none of it goes on a transcript or travels with your Growth Record.

- **What is never kept.** Scores. Rankings. Assessments of your character written by anyone but you. Any note about you that you have not read. Any file that follows you past this year.

You can ask to read anything written about you, at any time, and the guide will show you. If you think a note is wrong, say so, and it gets corrected. That includes a Pause, a Stop or a Strike: if you think a call was wrong, say so, and it can come off - off the note and off the count. You do not have to be calm about it. A learner who is angry at an unfair call is giving us information, not failing a condition.

That is the whole of it. "No surveillance" is a promise about this list, and the list is short on purpose.

The Growth Record, and whether any of this counts on paper

You are sixteen to eighteen, so a fair question about any year of your life is whether it counts on paper. Here is the straight answer.

The Compass holds a record called your **Growth Record**, and the whole design of it is that you own it and the studio does not. The app is a lens, not a vault: you hold the keys from the first day, and a guide is a guest whose access ends when the relationship does. A school cannot lose, withhold or hold hostage a record it never held in the first place.

It has two faces, and you control which one anybody sees.

- **The Journey view** is the whole trail, in order, with the slow parts and the stalls in it. It stays private. It is yours.
- **The Portrait view** is the one you would hand a college, an employer or a programme. It is framed as what you can actually do, and **you choose what goes into it, piece by piece.** Nobody assembles your Portrait for you, and nobody sends it anywhere without you.

One rule holds across both, and it is built into the thing rather than promised about it: growth here is only ever shown as **movement compared to your own earlier self.** Never a grade. Never a score. Never set beside another learner.

And the honest limit, which you should hear from us rather than discover. The part that lets the record physically leave - a real export, readable by a human, held in your hands - **is not finished yet.** It is being built. Until it exists, nobody walks the Launch at the end of the three years, because a ceremony that hands you something that is not there is not a ceremony. That

rule reaches anyone leaving at the end of this year too: the leaving rite in Part 4 is the same Launch, with the same condition. That is a rule the programme put on itself before any learner was in the room.

Two more things, said plainly. High-school credit is tracked separately, and it is the one record other people read as a routine matter, which is the honest exception to the first promise. And a transcript from a studio like this one is not yet a thing every college recognises; the bridge to dual enrollment is real work and we will do it alongside you rather than pretending it is already finished.

Joining at the Forge (a note for a learner starting here)

You do not have to have done the first year to start The Forge. Some learners begin their Launch Pad story right here, and that is a real beginning, not a late one.

Origin does one quiet job: it gives a person three things to stand on. The Forge leans on those three things, so if you are joining here, you will build a short version of them in your own work time over the first few weeks. We call it the short Origin. In plain terms, the three things are:

- **A self named.** Some sense of who you are and what you dream about. You will do a fast version of naming your own dreams, on the same card Origin uses: a hundred is the target, not a gate, and borrowed dreams count.
- **Agency claimed.** The felt knowledge that your choices matter and that you can move some things in your life. You will take a quick stock of what you actually have to work with.
- **A routine that holds.** A rhythm for your days that fits you, so the work has somewhere to live.

There is a card for each one, in print, in large print, and read aloud on a recording, so you can take it in the way you take things in. You build them in your own-day blocks across the first four weeks, and the midday check-in on those days is where you ask about them. They can be picked up again any time, they are never a test, and nobody grades them. Nobody can see who is doing them. By the time the group names the problem each person will carry, most people have enough of "what's mine" to name a problem that is genuinely theirs; if you don't yet, you carry a smaller problem or a placeholder, and that is a real start. In the shared work, you are a full Forge learner from the very first day. There is no catch-up table.

Part 2 - For the guide: teaching this year

The shape of the year, and naming the destination on day one

The Forge runs the full Vibrant Life year, mid-August to late May, on the school's calendar rather than a tidy one of its own, and it takes the same shape as Origin: seven sessions with a break between each, thirty-one weeks of session work, plus the three-week Open Waters tail, for thirty-four program weeks in all. The sessions are **not** equal lengths. They are set by where the breaks fall.

The Forge 2028-2029. A program week is Monday to Thursday: two guide mornings (Tuesday and Thursday), two the learners run themselves (Monday and Wednesday), and Friday fallow.

Session	Dates	Weeks
S1 Naming the Dragon	Aug 14 - Sep 7	4
session break	Sep 11 - 14	
S2 The Detective	Sep 18 - Oct 19	5
session break	Oct 23 - 26	
S3 My Arena	Oct 30 - Nov 16	3
Thanksgiving	Nov 20 - 24	
S4 The Wider Field	Nov 27 - Dec 14	3
Winter break	Dec 18 - 29	
S5 The Long Game	Jan 1 - Feb 8	6
session break	Feb 12 - 15	
S6 Hands to Work	Feb 19 - Mar 29	6
session break	Apr 2 - 5	

Session	Dates	Weeks
S7 The Call to Action	Apr 9 - May 3	4
Open Waters (flex tail)	May 7 - May 24	3

Five Mondays inside sessions are holidays: Labor Day (Sep 4) in S1, the second Monday of October (Oct 9) in S2, New Year's Day (Jan 1) as S5's first day, MLK Day (Jan 15) in S5, and Presidents Day (Feb 19) on S6's first day. A Monday here is a self-run morning rather than a guided one. One guide day in S3 is a holiday: Election Day, Tue Nov 7, a presidential election that year. Whether the studio observes it is decided before S3 opens. Veterans Day falls on a Saturday that year and is observed on Fri Nov 10, a fallow day, so it takes no program day.

> *These dates take Origin's 2027-2028 shape and begin it on Monday, August 14, 2028, around that year's real Thanksgiving week. They are a projection. One thing the real calendar will move: as printed, New Year's Day is S5's first Monday, so expect the winter break a week later. Jenna, who runs the school, sets the real dates. Confirm them before anything is printed for a family.*

The sessions below are cut to these weeks. Where the calendar gave a session more weeks than its plan, the extra went to one of two places: air, so the threshold rites and the learner's own dig each get a day of their own, and the year's one fallow week, named as such in Session 2. Nothing was added because a week existed.

Every session ends into a break, so every session carries the same two seams. On the last guided day, the carry-out: the pace question, the harvest, and the closing minute at session scale. On the first guided day back, the re-thread. The re-ask is rarer and is asked three times, where there is still time to act on the answer: at the winter break, which is The Wider Field's last guided day; after The Long Game; and on the year-close day. The agreements are open for reopening at every session's close too - say so on the last guided day, every time, so the handle is real and not only promised in week one.

On day one, name where the year is going. Say it plainly:

> SAY
>
> "In May, you'll stand up in front of a room and tell them what's worth solving and what you're asking of them. We call it the Call to Action. Everything between now and then is getting ready to mean it."

A destination named on day one is a gift, not a deadline; it gives the whole year a shape the learner can feel. No week count in the line: the count is not settled, and a date that moves is a promise broken.

The year opens with a shared threshold that the whole room crosses together - returners and joiners in the same doorway, never a remedial side door for the new arrivals. Returners re-open their Origin Captain's Log and pull one dream forward: "which of your one hundred dreams is a problem you could act on? Which broke your heart enough to name?" Origin's harvest becomes The Forge's premise. This is offered, never required - a returner may carry a wholly new dream, and that is theirs to choose.

For any learner joining mid-cycle, three things make "joining in progress" real rather than a polite word for behind: the Captain's Log from day one, peer-witness pairs in which each witnesses the other naming a dream (not tutoring, witnessing), and the short Origin built quietly in their own work blocks across the first four weeks. Pair everyone, mixed, and only where both have said yes; a pairing that marks the joiner is the catch-up table the learner's page says does not exist. No visible catch-up.

The year's daily ritual: the Impossible Question

Every guide day opens, after the settle and the circle, with an Impossible Question - a question with no clean answer, debated playfully. The circle comes first because you cannot stand inside something enormous while nobody in the room knows you are tired. "Could we end loneliness?" "Can one person change a system?" The point is never to answer it. The point is to grow comfortable standing inside something too big to close.

Name it plainly when it begins: this is the same muscle you have been building since the first year. In Origin it was small choice games - making real decisions and feeling their consequences. Here it grows into standing inside questions too big to close. In the final year it becomes the hard call inside a no-win. Small choices, then big questions, then the hard call - one continuous muscle, deepening. Say so at each handoff or the three-year payoff goes silent.

The safety floor

You are a life-coach and a mentor, not a licensed clinician. This year surfaces real problems, real heartbreak, and hard days by design. Clinical material will come up. Your job is not to treat it - it is to recognize it, hold the moment safely, and route it to real help fast.

The settle, the way down, the exit ramp, the close-return. These moves are fixed and run every guide day (see Part 1; the learner reads the same words you do). Open with the settle. Fix your own wording for it in the first week, write it down, and then do not improve it, because the sameness is the medicine: a settle improvised fresh each day never becomes the reflex a body can drop into without thinking, and if it goes stale to you, that is it working. Seat the way down in the seam between a deep block and the shared meal, and again at the end of any day that ends heavy - do not send a learner home on a still-activated body. Keep the exit ramp real: a named place, a no-scene re-entry. Say the close-return in its fixed words after any day that went somewhere heavy. And run the closing minute at the close of every guide day, light days included; "take your closing minute" is the whole prompt, and you never ask what came up.

The referral pathway, in plain terms. Some things are past coaching, and when you see them you route, you do not work them in a session. Route now, do not coach, if you see or hear any of these: any mention of suicide, self-harm, or not wanting to be here; abuse, neglect, or someone hurting them; a crisis happening right now: panic, a flashback, feeling cut off from their own body, or distress you cannot reach; signs of something going wrong with eating; a crisis with drugs or alcohol; a threat to someone else; something past an ordinary hard day: it keeps going, and it is getting in the learner's way. When in doubt, route. Being sure is a clinician's job, not yours.

In the moment: stay with the learner, never leave them alone; move to the quiet space you prepared before the year opened; be present and calm and listening; do not fix, do not ask for details, do not counsel; do not promise a secrecy you cannot keep. In Idaho everyone is a mandatory reporter, including you - suspected abuse or neglect gets reported, ideally within twenty-four hours, and you do not need proof, because the law gives the judging to the state; your job is to tell, theirs to find out. For immediate danger, 988 (call, text, or chat) or 911 if life-threatening. This duty does not give you a key to the Log. You do not read it, so it cannot be a source. What the duty reaches is what a learner tells you, shows you or hands you, and what you see and hear in the room. Say that distinction out loud on day one: the Log is never read, and what you are told, you may have to act on. The named local therapist you can warm-refer to must be a real person arranged before the year opens - "route to real help" is only real if the help is real. The pathway runs across breaks, not only on program days, and the learner is told so before each one.

Keep confidences safe. Say the privacy words on day one, woven into the promises you make each other, and say them as written rather than improvising a warmer version, because a learner who hears a different wording than the one they read goes looking for the seam:

> SAY
>
> "Almost everything you write and say here is yours. Your Captain's Log, nobody reads - including me, and I won't go looking. What I can't keep private is a short list, and I'd rather you hear it now than find out later: if you're in danger, if someone's hurting you, or if something's going on that's bigger than I can hold here. That's when I bring in real help, and usually that means a call home too. I'll tell you when I'm doing it. That's not breaking trust - it's what care actually looks like."

Those are the same promises that are on the learner's privacy page in Part 1, in your own voice. A confidentiality limit named up front is a promise kept. Named in the moment, it feels like betrayal.

After any hard moment, debrief with your own named person - do not carry it alone. Document factually and minimally: what happened, what you did, who you contacted, never the learner's private content, because a safety note holding their own words becomes the copy of their life the Log promise forbids.

The real-service guardrails

This year the work goes out to real people, and that raises the stakes. Hold these:

- **Design with, never for.** The learner designs the work alongside the people who have the problem, not on their behalf, because the people who have the problem are the only ones who can say whether it moved; a fix designed for them is the fixer's idea of their life. Talk to real, affected humans, early and often, and let them shape the work.
- **Never do service *at* a community as a lesson.** The community names its own need. A project does not touch real people until a named community member is invited (not just interviewed for data) and agrees - to the project, its terms, and a way to say "stop." They are the one party this year that did not enrol here, so their yes is the only thing that makes this service rather than practice on them. Between the invitation and the yes there is a wait, and the wait is the work.
- **Name where the benefit flows, up front.** If the honest answer is "they are part of my learning project," that is the savior trap, and naming it early is how you catch it. The harvest sits with the community's verdict - "did this serve you?" - not the learner's guess.
- **Build in a repair clause.** If a project lands wrong on the people it touched, there is a calm, named way to make it right. Repair is part of the service, not its failure, because a project

with no way to be set right has no way to be told it went wrong, and the people it touched will not tell you without one.

- **Relationships outlast the harvest.** No drive-by service. Affected voices lead early, not consulted at the last minute. And no one's story enters the final talk without their consent, because a story is the strongest thing in a talk, which is exactly why it must belong to the one who lived it. Consent reaches back: what they take back comes out of the talk.
- **Do not send a learner into a situation heavier than the support around them.** With people who are easily harmed, match the mode to the learner's readiness; stay close. Service should stretch, not wound, because stretch is the point and a wound teaches the wrong thing. Any work with people who are easily harmed gets a real adult's support, and so does the graceful ending of any community relationship.

Holding a "no"

Decline-with-reasoning lives or dies in the single moment a learner actually says no. If that moment collapses into invisible opt-out - silence, the activity just continues around them - the learner is protected by being erased from the room. So hold a no in three beats, and you can run them under load:

1. **Receive the no, whole.** "Okay. You're not doing this one." Honor it *before* any curiosity, so your curiosity never lands as a lever.
2. **Offer the door once, and don't push it.** "That no stands, and it's done. When you've worked out what's behind it, the tribe will want to hear it. Not me - them. And not today." Hold both halves or you have turned the practice into a toll: the reasoning is genuinely owed to the room, and it is genuinely not owed in the moment. If a learner never comes back to it, that is between them and the tribe, and it is not yours to collect.
3. **Keep them inside the encounter.** "Come sit with me - you don't have to do the thing." Removing the task is not the same as removing the person.

Your curious question, when you offer it, stays a mirror and never a way to scare someone into yes. Ask "when do you think you'll first run into this for real?" - never "what happens the first time you need this and no one is beside you?" The first opens a door with curiosity; the second forecasts them alone and unequipped, which lands on an anxious learner as "you'll be sorry." And whether a fear is "the right kind of scared" is the learner's to name about themselves, never yours to assign. The instant you re-code a reasoned no as "avoidance" so you can override it, you have smuggled the veto back in as a diagnosis. You have a voice. You never have a veto.

Watch-fors, and protect yourself

Eco-anxiety and despair. Meeting real, world-sized problems can swamp anyone, and at sixteen it can swamp hard, which is why the field is always paired with a slice the learner can move. The whole antidote runs in two moves. First, agency: always pair the wider field with a slice the learner can actually move - you do not have to solve all of it. Second, and deeper, love: begin the outward turn with what the learner loves about being alive on this planet, before you show them the world's hunger. Agency cures powerlessness, but only love cures despair. You fight for what you love, not against what you hate. If a learner comes grieving the world, name the grief as legitimate and sit with it before anything else - "grief is love with nowhere to go. It can sit here a while. When you're ready, and not before, we can ask where it wants to go." Route anything heavy to real support.

Some lives have mostly been facts of life so far. Some learners arrive with a world that has mostly been things that happened, not things to fix. That is the honest shape of some lives, not a lack in the person, and naming one small problem in reach is the whole win. A small arena is not a small person. "The quiet arena is the invitation."

The mapper is in the map. Wherever a learner meets a problem, add the standpoint question: "Where are you inside this system? What does it let you see, and what does it hide? What do the people who live it see that you can't?" This turns design-with from a rule obeyed into a truth understood.

Crew, never watch. Every net in this room is phrased as a crew that holds each other, never as a watch set on a fragile person. A crew keeps the person at the centre the one steering. A watch set on someone turns them into the thing being watched, and the room into the hero of their story. Do not let the safety architecture quietly make the room the hero and the learner the thing it protects.

Your own settle. You spend your own steadiness settling a room all morning, solo, in a week that is otherwise parenting a toddler. Run your own settle, your own way down at day's end, and your own closing minute - as safety instrumentation, not as self-care. A depleted guide cannot run the watch-and-pivot the whole floor depends on. Do a weekly presence-check: "was I whole for the deep hour this week, or was I bailing water?" The lighter shape of this year *is* the floor working - a smaller tribe or a further-lightened year is the design honoring you, not you failing. What you can hold sets how many learners are in the room, and both come before money, because a learner enrolled on coverage not yet secured is one the floor cannot hold, and the day it fails is the day you find out. And there is a pre-written, honorable permission to defer

the whole thing if the year outgrows the sustainable shape, written while rested because rested is the only time it can be: a depleted person does not pause on instinct.

Your fallow day is fallow too, and so are the breaks. Protected, not on-call. The learner's page says plainly that you are not reachable over a break, so you never have to improvise that limit on the last guided day; what you say aloud before each break is who is: the one adult outside the room, and 988. Every session here ends into a break: the September break after Naming the Dragon, the October break after The Detective, Thanksgiving after My Arena, the two-week winter break after The Wider Field and its expedition, the February break after The Long Game, the April break after Hands to Work, and after the Call to Action, Open Waters and then the summer, the longest absence in the cycle. Say it on the last guided day, every time, in one fixed form: "The break starts Friday and runs [length]. I won't be reachable - that's my rest too. [Name] is, the whole time, not only on studio days; here is how to reach them. 988 is free and open all day and all night, call or text, from anywhere. The path to real help stays open the whole break. I'm back in the room on [day]."

Part 3 - The sessions

Each session below gives you: what it's for, a short plain intro for the learner, the flow day by day, things you might say aloud, the settle and closing minute, watch-fors, and what you'll need.

A note on the flow tables: Monday and Wednesday are your own days (you run your own hours; check-in around midday). Tuesday is the lighter guide day. Thursday is the deep guide day. Friday is fallow and closes the week. Each session header carries its calendar weeks and projected dates; the week labels inside a session count from that session's first week. The weeks inside a session follow one small grammar, and the word in brackets after each week says which beat it is: a session opens, deepens, applies, and harvests. The week the work leaves the room and comes back is a gather. A three-week session doubles up. Session 2's fourth week is named what it is: fallow.

One word about words. Part 1 said the Log is kept however you hold it, and that holds all year. When the sessions below say write, draft, or read, and when a day line says Log, they mean put it in your Log and go back to it, in whatever form yours takes. The book says write because it is the shortest word, not because it is the only way. The same holds for stand, walk, and speak: they mean take part in the way your body takes part. And anything the room listens to has a transcript in the room; anything the room reads can be heard. Both are on the table for everyone before anyone needs them; nobody has to ask.

Session 1 - Naming the Dragon (four weeks, Aug 14 - Sep 7)

What it's for: Learn the difference between a problem, a fact of life, a preference, and a mystery - and name the one problem you will carry all year, precisely enough to actually fight it.

For the learner: The first week is the threshold. You help write this year's agreements whether you were here last year or not; last year's do not carry over. Then the work. "Everything sucks" is a dragon too big and too foggy to fight. A dragon you can name - the specific, actual thing,

said clearly enough that you would know what moving it looks like - is a dragon you can face. This session hands you a distinction almost no one gets handed as a teenager: some hard things are problems you can act on, some are facts of life you accept, some are just preferences, and some are mysteries you sit with. You work on each of them differently. By the end you may name the one dragon you will trace and act on all year. If you are still searching for yours, that is honest and honored - a dragon can't be forced, and "I'm still looking" is a true harvest.

The flow:

> *Weeks 1-4 · Aug 14 - Sep 7 · off: Mon Sep 4, Labor Day*

The fourth week goes to the front, as Origin's did, and the mixed room is the stronger reason, not a weaker one. In Origin the risk was exposure among strangers. Here the risk is inheritance: a joiner signing a floor they did not write, in a room where six people already know where the cups are. A floor the returners wrote last year cannot be consented to by a joiner this year; it can only be accepted. So the first week is where the room that will live under the floor writes it, both halves as authors, carried on a shared task where history is no advantage: setting up the room for the year. No Forge content in the week.

Week 1 - the threshold (open). - **Mon (your own):** returners' own morning: re-open the Origin Log, restart the core rhythm. A joiner's first day is Tuesday, by design; one who chooses to come today is met at the door and shown the building, and the guide says who will be down the hall. Check-in. - **Tue (lighter guide day):** arrival, then the door. The walk-in, the settle, the first circle with a name round and "how are you, really?" (pass is always allowed), the Table, the map of the year, and the destination named. Then the exit ramp built and walked by everyone before any promise is asked for - returners walk it again, because last year's ramp was last year's room. Then the privacy words as written, the one adult outside the room named, and breaks said. All of it carried on the shared task of setting up the room for the year: the exit-ramp place, the quiet space, the Table, the dragons wall. No Impossible Question today, no pairs, no Forge content. - **Wed (your own):** the interval: promises offered, nothing owed back. Returners, core. Joiners, the short Origin's first card in their own block, where nobody can see who is doing it. Check-in. - **Thu (deep guide day):** the tribe's own half. Say the floor first: six things this tribe cannot agree to, the six it was promised. Then the agreements, written fresh by this room - a returner who offers reads last year's aloud as a starting point, not a text, because the count cleared and the room is new - contributions on cards or aloud, named as reopenable and told when. Say what happens if a learner will not sign: in the room anyway. Then, last and separate, the carried objects for joiners: name your Log with every form on the table, name your Vineyard-thing; a returner says their Vineyard's name aloud only if they choose. The close's one light thing is the first Impossible Question, named as the handoff: the same muscle as Origin's choice games, now standing inside something too big to close. At the very end of the week, send home the dragon-watch ("notice one thing that bugs you this week") and offer the returner reach-back: "which of your hundred dreams is a problem you could act on? Bring that one next week, or a new one, or neither yet." - **Fri:** fallow.

Week 2 - the distinction (deepen). - **Mon (your own):** returners pull a dream forward, or carry a new one; joiners continue the short Origin; everyone carries the dragon-watch; core. Check-in. - **Tue (lighter guide day):** Impossible Question, in its place from now on. Peer-witness pairs set in the walk-in, mixed, only where both have said yes, now that a yes means something. Then "Problem or Not?" - cards with real situations sorted into four buckets; the arguments over the gray cards are the whole lesson. - **Wed (your own):** apply the four buckets to the thing that bugged you; core; Log. Check-in. - **Thu (deep guide day):** the distinction held on real material - problem, fact of life, preference, mystery - and the Iceberg begun (the surface problem versus the thing underneath). Bridge: watch for your own dragon. - **Fri:** fallow.

Week 3 - name it precisely (apply). - **Mon (your own):** reframe one of your own complaints; core; Log; joiners continue the short Origin. Check-in. - **Tue (lighter guide day):** Impossible Question; then "Reframe-It to How Might We" as a group game - crank a complaint ("history is pointless")

into an open design question ("how might we make this matter?"). A complaint is a closed door; a How-Might-We is an open one. - **Wed (your own):** apply the Iceberg to a real complaint - what's underneath it? Core; Log. Check-in. - **Thu (deep guide day):** where's the dragon really? Each learner brings a candidate problem and works to name it precisely - not "everything sucks" but the specific, actionable thing. Bridge: refine your named dragon. - **Fri:** fallow.

Week 4 - name the dragon you'll carry (harvest). - **Mon:** Labor Day; no studio. - **Tue (lighter guide day):** Impossible Question; share candidate dragons, and the peer-witness pairs witness each other naming one (borrowed dreams count, and a joiner has had three weeks to find one); find "problem-neighbors" (whose problem rhymes with yours - the start of collaboration); light peer feedback. - **Wed (your own):** the interval, named out loud as one: the learners run it themselves, carrying one question, handing in nothing. Late in the session they can hold their own silence, which they could not in week 1. - **Thu (deep guide day, harvest):** each learner names the dragon they'll carry, or says they are still looking. A small voluntary share. Ask the pace question; run the closing minute at session scale; say aloud who is reachable over the break, and that you are not. Bridge into Session 2: "You've named the dragon. Next: trace it to its root - the obvious villain is almost never the cause." - **Fri:** fallow, closes Session 1.

Things to say: - "A vague dragon can't be fought. A named one can. Naming precisely is half the victory." - "Is that a problem you can act on, or a fact of life you accept? A fact of life doesn't answer to effort. Fighting one can wear you out, and that's not a fault in you." - "I'm still searching for mine" - honor it whole: "That's a true harvest. You can't force a problem to matter." - "Last year's agreements were last year's room. This room writes its own."

The settle and the closing minute: open every guide day with the settle; close every guide day with the closing minute, "take your closing minute" as the whole prompt. Run it at session scale on the harvest day, Thu Sep 7, and ask the pace question before the bridge.

Watch-fors: if a learner's hard things turn out to be facts of life, they have not failed to solve anything; hold the distinction gently. Complaints can surface real pain - hold, do not treat, route if it's past coaching.

What you'll need: the "Problem or Not?" cards (real situations for the four buckets), in large print and read aloud as each is drawn, with the Iceberg drawn and also said in words; the three short-Origin cards for any joiner (dreams, what-I-have, a week that holds), each in print, large print, and audio; peer-witness pairs set by consent in week 2; the exit-ramp place, set up before Tuesday; one shared setting-up task to carry the first week; cards for agreement contributions; the map of the year to hand out; last year's agreements, for a returner to read if one offers; the

one adult outside the room, written; the childcare for every guide morning, confirmed before the year opens; the quiet space and referral roster live before day one.

Session 2 - The Detective (five weeks, Sep 18 - Oct 19)

What it's for: Learn root-cause thinking - keep asking "why" until you hit the system underneath - and trace your own dragon down to the rot beneath it.

For the learner: The obvious culprit is almost never the real cause. This session you work a mystery the tribe picks, and you learn one tool, the 5 Whys: keep asking why until you reach the pattern underneath. The villain everyone suspects usually turns out to be a symptom, and the cause is a system, which means a set of choices people keep making. Then, if you want, you turn the same tool on your own dragon. There is a second half: a system is made of choices, so you also ask who is still answerable inside it. Cause and who-is-answerable, together: that is the whole of justice. Some dragons, dug into, turn out to be facts of life and not problems. That is a true finding, not a failed one. You dig as far as you choose and stop where you choose, and the dig has no finish date inside the session: the fourth week is the week the answer is allowed to not be in yet, and it is the year's one fallow week, empty on purpose.

One straight thing first: the mystery is usually a murder, the board-game kind - cartoonish, bloodless, nobody real - and the trick of it is that every suspect looks guilty until you find the system underneath. If a made-up death is not what you want to spend two weeks on, for any reason or none, there is a version with the same puzzle and no body in it: who sabotaged the harvest festival, who killed the river. Same mechanics, same twist. Ask once and nobody asks why.

The flow:

Weeks 5-9 · Sep 18 - Oct 19 · off: Mon Oct 9, Indigenous Peoples' Day / Columbus Day, in week 4

The dig has no finish date inside the session. The mystery takes two weeks and ends in a twist. Your own dragon takes as long as it takes: the tool turns to it in week 3, and week 4 is the week the answer is allowed to not be in yet. Nobody is waited on but you. "I stopped here" and "it's a fact of life" are places to stand, not places to be moved from, and nobody asks what is under them in front of the room.

Week 1 - set the mystery (open, re-thread). - **Mon (your own):** core; begin gathering facts about your own dragon from Session 1, or, if you are starting here, begin the short Origin and carry a placeholder dragon or a smaller one; Log. Check-in. - **Tue (lighter guide day):** the re-thread first - where were you, where are you now, what came back changed over the break; peer-witness pairs set for anyone new, mixed, only where both have said yes; Impossible Question; then the tribe picks the format - a ready whodunit, build-your-own mystery for another group, or a roam-the-room speakeasy - and the mystery begins (for example, "A Death at Greywater Manor," six guests, each a motive; every suspect looks guilty in turn - that's the trap). A learner starting this week has a full vote; it is the first thing the tribe decides with them in it. - **Wed (your own):** investigate the mystery; core; joiners continue the short Origin; Log. Check-in. - **Thu (deep guide day):** introduce the 5 Whys and run it once, on the mystery - ask why of the death, then why of the answer, until it bottoms out. Name what one chain is: a ladder, and a ladder is never the whole of a system. Bridge: "Next week we start again from the same body and see whether we land in the same place." - **Fri:** fallow.

Week 2 - the twist (deepen). - **Mon (your own):** core; investigate; one more fact about your own dragon; joiners continue the short Origin; Log. Check-in. - **Tue (lighter guide day):** Impossible Question; continue the mystery; the Iceberg revisited on the mystery - what sits under the six motives? - **Wed (your own):** core; investigate; Log. Check-in. - **Thu (deep guide day):** run the 5 Whys three times from the same symptom, finding a different root each pass, then look for the loop where the roots feed each other. The loop is the twist: "no one murdered her; a system did." A system is a web, not a ladder. Then the arrow both ways, inside the fiction, where it is safe to practise: a system is made of choices people keep making, so who in Greywater Manor is still answerable? Where does the system stop being an excuse - for the powerful first? The mystery closes here. Bridge: "Next week the tool turns to your own dragon, if you want it to." - **Fri:** fallow.

Week 3 - the tool on your own dragon (apply). - **Mon (your own):** core; a first 5 Whys pass on your own dragon, or on your placeholder; a joiner's short Origin finishes about now and can go on being picked up; Log. Check-in. - **Tue (lighter guide day):** Impossible Question; the Iceberg on your own dragon, in company, lightly - what is it sitting on? Low stakes: nobody reads out a root. - **Wed (your own):** core; a second pass from the same symptom; Log. Check-in. - **Thu (deep guide day):** the transfer - the system beneath your dragon and the choices inside it. The arrow both ways, asked of the powerful first; "you can ask it of yourself if you choose to," and the choosing is the learner's. Then name the two findings out loud before anyone has made them, so nobody is surprised by their own: some dragons, dug into, are facts of life; and some digs stop

before the bottom. Both are places to stand. Bridge: "Dig as far as you choose. It comes back when it comes." - **Fri:** fallow.

Week 4 - the fallow week, and it stays empty (gather). No new detective work. **This is the year's one deliberately empty stretch inside the arc, and it is un-harvested: no Work of the Day, nothing reported, nothing to hand in.** The grid still runs - the settle, the circle, the Impossible Question, the Table, the close - and the middle block is low-stakes craft, or nothing. The temptation to refill it the first time it looks idle is the exact thing it exists to resist. The guide's work this week is the walk-in, for whoever wants to say where the dig stands: at the bottom, still going, stopped on purpose, or a fact of life. "Stopped on purpose" closes the question, and nobody is asked it twice. Nobody is behind. A root you reach under the shovel is not the root; the dig needs a week where nobody is digging. - **Mon:** off, Indigenous Peoples' Day / Columbus Day. - **Tue (lighter guide day):** Impossible Question; then craft or nothing - if the tribe chose build-your-own, the finished mystery is handed to the group it was built for; if not, a game, or the hands block early. The dig is talked about in the walk-in, one to one, if at all. - **Wed (your own):** core; the dig, if it is still going; Log. Check-in. - **Thu (deep guide day):** left empty on purpose. No new tool. The room is open to work your dig in company, with the guide or a problem-neighbour, for anyone who wants it, and hands and each other for anyone who does not; nobody says which they are doing. - **Fri:** fallow.

Week 5 - what's under it (harvest). - **Mon (your own):** core; finish, or leave unfinished, your 5 Whys on your dragon; Log. Check-in. - **Tue (lighter guide day):** Impossible Question; share early root-cause findings, voluntary; find problem-neighbours by shared system - whose dragon sits on the same web as yours; the start of collaboration, and also where a learner who stopped digging can look at a neighbour's root without owning it. - **Wed (your own):** core; name the system underneath your dragon, or name where you stopped; Log. Check-in. - **Thu (deep guide day, harvest):** each learner names the root or system beneath their dragon, or "fact of life," or "I stopped here," or "a placeholder, dug into" - all four equal (voluntary share). Ask the pace question. Say aloud who is reachable over the Oct 23-26 break, and that you are not. Run the closing minute at session scale. Bridge into Session 3: "You've found the system. Next: where in it can *you* actually act?" - **Fri:** fallow, closes Session 2.

Things to say: - "The obvious villain is a symptom. Underneath it is a system: things people keep doing. That's what we're looking for." - "A system isn't a ladder you climb down. It's a web. Find where the causes feed each other." - "A system explains a lot. Where does it stop explaining, and someone's choice begin? Ask it of the powerful first. You can ask it of yourself if you choose to." - "Dig as far as you choose. It comes back when it comes, and 'I stopped here' is a place to stand."

The settle and the closing minute: settle to open; the closing minute at every close, and at session scale after the harvest; the way down and the close-return on any day a learner's own root-cause dig touches something tender. The re-thread is the first thing on week 1's Tuesday; the pace question and the break line are on week 5's Thursday, Thu Oct 19, before the bridge.

Watch-fors: keep the mystery Clue-style, cartoonish, and bloodless - no graphic violence, because the mystery is a tool for root-cause, and a learner who has met real violence cannot use a tool that reopens it; the cartoon keeps the twist and drops the wound. The lighter swap is on the learner's page and offered to everyone, not produced for whoever needs it; opt-out always. This is a strong belonging session for a newcomer - the 5 Whys needs no Origin foundation. "My dragon turned out to be a fact of life, not a problem" is a real finding, not a failure, and it gets a week before anyone asks what is under it: a finding said in the hour it is found, in front of six peers, is a verdict; one the learner has sat with is theirs. The same holds for "I stopped here." The mystery is shared work a learner starting this week is inside from the first morning; their short Origin runs on the own-days alongside, and their dragon may be a placeholder all session.

What you'll need: the chosen mystery materials (a ready whodunit like Greywater Manor, or build-your-own supplies, or the space set up as a speakeasy), with every clue and character sheet in a form each learner can take in alone - read, heard, or large print - so the detective work is never routed through a sighted partner; the lighter non-murder swap ready; the 5 Whys as a simple, visible frame, also said in words.

Session 3 - My Arena (three weeks, Oct 30 - Nov 16, ends into Thanksgiving)

What it's for: Right-size the problem to the slice you can actually move, take an honest inventory of what you have to work with, and win one small real thing you can feel.

For the learner: You cannot fix all of a huge problem, and spending all your energy on the parts you can't reach wears a person out. This session finds your arena - the place where your own action actually moves something. You sort your worries into what you can control, what you can influence, and what you can only care about. You take stock of what you have right now: skills, time, people, things. That stock is for finding what you can act with. It is not a list of what you are missing, and a short list is not a small person; some lives hand a person less to work with, and saying so plainly is honest, not failing, because the whole session is built for the slice that is actually yours, whatever its size. Then you may pick one small real problem inside your reach and try to move it. Some starter quests work. Some don't, and what happened tells you

something about the arena, not about you. “I tried and it didn’t move” and “I haven’t found my slice yet” are both real harvests.

The flow:

Weeks 10-12 · Oct 30 - Nov 16 · on a guide day: Tue Nov 7, Election Day, observance decided before the session · ends into Thanksgiving

> *Week 1 - the Three Circles (open, re-thread).* - **Mon (your own):** core; list everything about your dragon you worry about; Log. Check-in. - **Tue (lighter guide day):** the re-thread first, short; Impossible Question; the Three Circles map (Concern / Influence / Control) - sort your worries; watch where energy can actually act. - **Wed (your own):** core; sit with your map; Log. Check-in. - **Thu (deep guide day):** right-sizing, by question - where does your energy move something, and where does it just burn? Concern-only turns into cynicism. Add the standpoint question: “Where are you standing inside this system? What does that let you see, and what does it hide?” Bridge: what do you actually have to act with? - **Fri:** fallow.

Week 2 - agency inventory and a starter quest (deepen, apply). - **Mon (your own):** core; agency inventory - skills, time, relationships, resources you have *now*; Log. Check-in. - **Tue (lighter guide day):** Impossible Question; finish the agency inventory; pick a starter quest - one small real problem inside your arena to act on. - **Wed (your own):** core; scope your starter quest small enough to actually finish; Log. Check-in. - **Thu (deep guide day):** the move from “it happens to me” to “I can act on this slice”; test the starter quest against the Three Circles - is it really in your influence or control? Bridge: begin acting. - **Fri:** fallow.

Week 3 - a thing you moved (harvest). - **Mon (your own):** act on the starter quest; core; Log. Check-in. - **Tue (lighter guide day):** Impossible Question; act, build, or share starter-quest progress in company. - **Wed (your own):** finish the starter quest; core; Log. Check-in. - **Thu (deep guide day, harvest):** a thing you moved - “this one is mine, and I moved it.” Some feel it as a win; some don’t yet; both count, and “it didn’t move” is a harvest too. Voluntary share. Ask the pace question. This is the last guided day before Thanksgiving, Thu Nov 16: say aloud who is reachable over the break, that 988 is always open, and that you are not; run the closing minute at session scale. Bridge into Session 4: “You’ve moved something in your arena. Now lift your eyes - what in the wider world gets to you?” - **Fri:** fallow, closes Session 3.

Things to say: - “Energy spent only on what you can’t touch tends to run out. Find the slice you can move, and spend some there.” - “You don’t have to solve all of it. You pick your slice.” - “Where are you standing inside this system - and what does that let you see, and hide?”

The settle and the closing minute: settle to open; the closing minute at every close, and at session scale after the harvest. Re-thread on the first guide day back.

Watch-fors: this whole session is the anti-despair move - a learner swamped by world-sized problems gets handed a slice they can move. A small arena is not a small person; acting on one real thing is the win at any scale. A starter quest that didn't work is data about the arena, never a verdict on the learner.

What you'll need: the Three Circles map (a simple three-ring diagram), and the same map as three plain lists, because a ring is a picture and a list is the same thing you can hear; the agency-inventory prompt; room for starter quests to actually run on project days.

Session 4 - The Wider Field (three weeks, Nov 27 - Dec 14, ends into the winter break)

What it's for: Lift your eyes from your own arena to the world, meet real problems where they live, and choose the one that breaks your heart - the one you'll carry through the rest of the year.

For the learner: Now you look outward. We start with what you love about being alive on this planet, before anything about what's wrong with it, because people fight for what they love. Then there is an expedition, off-site, to a real place where a real problem lives - a shelter, a food bank, a council meeting - and to one living place that is not a scene of failure, so you meet the world as something you belong to, not a broken machine you stand above. You can come and not go in, or stay back, and you can skip the trip and still carry a problem. By the end you may choose the problem you'll carry: not the one you think you should care about, the one that actually gets to you. The tribe also picks one shared problem together. If nothing has chosen you yet, say so. "Nothing has broken my heart yet, and I'm still looking" is a true answer, and the year goes on with you in it.

Three things said now, before the trip. Some of these problems may already be touching your life or your family's; if we visit a place you know from the inside, you are a member of that world, not its exhibit, and you choose how much of that travels back to the room: all, a little, or none. Meeting the world's hunger can bring real grief, which is honored here, not hurried; there is a named place to step out to on the trip. And you are a guest where we go. The people there did not enrol in your year. We arrive on time, we leave when they say, and nobody there becomes a story in your talk without saying yes.

The flow:

Weeks 13-15 · Nov 27 - Dec 14 · ends into the winter break

Week 1 - the wider field (open, re-thread). - **Mon (your own):** core; notice what in the world you can't stop thinking about; Log. Check-in. - **Tue (lighter guide day):** the re-thread first, short, after Thanksgiving; Impossible Question; love before heartbreak - begin with "what do you love about being alive on this planet?" (gladness before hunger). Then the Problem Gallery - a set of real-world problems laid out to move through (global goals, local issues, environmental, social); which one won't let you go? - **Wed (your own):** core; sit with the ones that pulled you; Log. Check-in. - **Thu (deep guide day):** "what breaks your heart?" - not what you should care about, what actually moves you. Pair every heartbreak with agency (your slice, not all of it). Bridge: come to the expedition ready to see one firsthand. - **Fri:** fallow.

Week 2 - the expedition (deepen). - **Mon (your own):** core; research a problem that pulled you; Log. Check-in. - **Tue (lighter guide day), the expedition:** go where a real problem lives (a shelter, a food bank, a council meeting) - and to at least one living-system site that is *not* a scene of failure (an old-growth stand, a wetland, a farm at harvest, a dark night sky). You are a thread in a living whole, not a technician above a broken machine. Ask the membership question: "How is this problem already touching your life? Where are you inside this system, not above it?" - **Wed (your own):** core; write what the expedition stirred; Log. Check-in. - **Thu (deep guide day):** debrief the expedition; the stakeholder intro (who actually *has* this problem?); re-anchor hope, not helplessness. Bridge: which problem will you carry? - **Fri:** fallow.

Week 3 - commit to the problem (apply, harvest), and the first half of the midpoint crossing. - **Mon (your own):** core; narrow toward the problem you'll carry; map its stakeholders; Log. Check-in. - **Tue (lighter guide day):** Impossible Question; share candidate problems; problem-neighbors (who might collaborate). - **Wed (your own):** core; commit; Log. Check-in. - **Thu (deep guide day, harvest):** each learner may commit to the world-problem they'll carry, or say they are still looking, *and* the tribe deliberates one shared "Commons Problem" into being - argued together, yielded to, chosen as a *we*, to carry to a shared chorus talk at the year's end. Name the relay: "you are one hand in a relay that began before you and continues after you - carry it your distance and pass it well, not 'I must solve it.'" Voluntary share. **This week holds the true midpoint of the year, and the midpoint is the winter break itself** - the fold between here and January, crossed with the learner's body out of the room. So the crossing comes in two halves, and this half is Thu Dec 14: the look-back across Sessions 1 to 4 (the dragon named, traced, a slice moved, the eyes lifted - who are you becoming?), the pace question, the re-ask (*is this still yours?*), asked to the room and answered one at a time in the walk-in or at the Table, never round the circle, and the re-entry note to your future self, so the problem committed this morning

survives two weeks of ordinary life. Say aloud who is reachable across the break, that 988 is always open, that you are not until January, and that the pathway stays live the whole time. Run the closing minute at session scale. Bridge into Session 5: "You've chosen what's worth solving. Next: can a big problem actually be solved - and how do you begin?" - **Fri:** fallow, closes Session 4.

Things to say: - "Acting on something helps with feeling powerless. For despair, what seems to help more is remembering what you love. So: what do you love about being alive?" - "Not what you should care about. What actually gets to you?" - "You're one hand in a relay that began before you and continues after you. Carry it your distance." - If grief surfaces: "Grief is love with nowhere to go. It can sit here a while. When you're ready, and not before, we can ask where it wants to go."

The settle and the closing minute: this session opens the interior wide (heartbreak, eco-despair), so it earns its close - the closing minute after the expedition and the Problem Gallery, and the way down at the end of the expedition-debrief day. Do not end the expedition day on a stakeholder map; a body that has absorbed the world's hunger needs to come home before it drives home.

Watch-fors (binding): world problems can swamp anyone in despair, and at sixteen they can swamp hard. Always pair the wider field with agency - hope, not helplessness. The expedition must not leave them crushed; some come back lit up, some flat, some tired, and the design's job is the floor, not the lift. Grief for the world is honored, not bypassed - witnessed, never excavated; route anything heavy to real support. The expedition is off-site, so the morning's childcare must cover the travel time as well - plan it per outing, and plan each site so every learner in the room can get there and take it in with the senses they have: a night sky is also cold air, quiet, and the smell of sage.

What you'll need: the Problem Gallery, each problem in a form that can be read, heard, or handled; expedition sites arranged (one problem site and one thriving living-system site), with the host told the shape of the visit; the membership and standpoint questions ready; off-site logistics and coverage planned; the number a late learner calls if the group has already left.

Session 5 - The Long Game (six weeks, Jan 1 - Feb 8)

What it's for: Learn that big problems are systems, not single heroic acts - break the impossible into a next doable step, find the real leverage, gather people, fail forward, and come out with a real plan and a first prototype.

For the learner: Things are only impossible until they're not. Nobody solves a big problem alone or in one move. This is the long session. It teaches you to break a big problem into a next real step, to find the lever where a small push moves a lot (the obvious levers are usually the weakest), to work with other people, and to treat what went wrong as information. There are three doors into it, each yours to open or leave shut: play, where being wrong is allowed; the child's question, "why not?"; and the shadow, meaning the uncomfortable truth inside a problem that people avoid. The shadow we look at is the problem's, never yours. The shadow day is one day, late in the session, and the lightest-touch day of the year: nobody will ask about your past, your family, or anything you carry, and you can sit that day out and still finish the session. You'll also be asked what pushes back if your fix works, the honest question that keeps you from playing the savior. "This problem is bigger than one year" is a real plan, and you can say it without shame.

This session opens the Monday after the winter break, and its first guided day is the second half of the midpoint crossing: the big re-thread as the whole morning, not a warm-up. Where were you, where are you now, what came back changed; the carried problem picked back up and checked against what two weeks of ordinary life showed; the safety floor said aloud again before a session that holds a shadow door. The clowning starts on the Thursday.

The flow:

Weeks 16-21 · Jan 1 - Feb 8 · off: Mon Jan 1, New Year's Day (the session's first day as projected; the real break likely moves); Mon Jan 15, MLK Day · no break inside this session

Week 1 - systems, not single acts (open, re-thread). - **Mon (your own):** core; is my problem a system? map its parts; Log. Check-in. - **Tue (lighter guide day):** the big re-thread, the whole morning (above). Nothing else is asked today. - **Wed (your own):** core; where's the leverage in my system? Log. Check-in. - **Thu (deep guide day):** the Impossible Question at full strength, and the clowning and play intro (failing-forward, "yes-and"). Then: can big problems be solved? Systems, not single acts; no hero alone. The leverage-ladder: tweak-a-number, then change-a-rule or who-enforces-it, then change-the-goal, then change-the-story everyone believes - and the obvious levers (a rule, more funding, more awareness) are usually the weakest. Bridge: find a lever, name which rung it's on, and a higher rung you haven't tried yet.

Week 2 - next doable steps (deepen). - **Mon (your own):** core; break the impossible into the next doable step; Log. Check-in. - **Tue (lighter guide day):** Impossible Question; more clowning and play - the clown fails constantly and turns failure into delight; permission to be gloriously wrong. - **Wed (your own):** core; name your next doable step; Log. Check-in. - **Thu (deep guide day):** next doable steps, and how each small win makes the next one feel possible; how a big problem yields to small, real, next steps. Ask the pace question here, Thu Jan 11, two clear weeks before the shadow door, so there is still time to act on the answer. Bridge: take one step.

Week 3 - the inner child door (deepen). - **Mon (your own):** core; take a real step on your problem; Log. Check-in. - **Tue (lighter guide day):** Impossible Question; the inner-child door - children ask "why not?" before anyone teaches them a thing is impossible; reconnect to fearless curiosity. - **Wed (your own):** core; "why not?" applied to your problem; Log. Check-in. - **Thu (deep guide day):** collaboration - who else is working on this? No one solves a system alone; find your collaborators. Bridge: reach one.

Week 4 - the shadow door (deepen). - **Mon (your own):** core; what's the uncomfortable truth inside your issue? Log. Check-in. - **Tue (lighter guide day):** Impossible Question; light, held play after the shadow prep. - **Wed (your own):** core; sit with the shadow *of the problem*; Log. Check-in. - **Thu (deep guide day), the shadow:** the uncomfortable truth most big problems stay unsolved because everyone avoids it. Of the problem, never the self. Opt-out, lightest touch, invitational. Accountability with compassion: the people inside the shadow are also inside the system - repair includes them, it doesn't just defeat them. Guard against the shadow hardening into contempt for a villain. Bridge: what does naming the shadow open?

Week 5 - prototype (apply). - **Mon (your own):** core; build the smallest real prototype of a solution-step; Log. Check-in. - **Tue (lighter guide day):** Impossible Question; prototyping in company; iterate from what happened, not what you hoped. - **Wed (your own):** core; test your prototype; Log. Check-in. - **Thu (deep guide day):** iteration and failing-forward; change one thing based on

what actually happened. And: "if your action works, what pushes back?" Name one likely unintended consequence of your own plan - the antidote to the savior posture, which requires believing your fix does only what you meant. Bridge: refine toward a real plan.

Week 6 - a plan and a prototype (harvest). - **Mon (your own):** core; consolidate your plan; Log. Check-in. - **Tue (lighter guide day):** Impossible Question; share plans and prototypes; peer feedback. - **Wed (your own):** core; ready your plan; Log. Check-in. - **Thu (deep guide day, harvest):** a real plan plus a first prototype for acting on the problem, or honestly not yet. Voluntary share. Ask the pace question, and the re-ask (*is this still yours?*), answered one at a time in the walk-in or at the Table, never round the circle: after the long middle session, before design-with service begins, is the yes that matters, and there are ten weeks left to act on a no. Run the closing minute at session scale, Thu Feb 8, and say aloud who is reachable over the break. Bridge into Session 6: "You have a plan. Now: real action, with real people."

Fallow every Friday, all six weeks.

Things to say: - "Big problems are systems, not single acts. No hero solves them alone." - "The obvious levers - a rule, more funding, more awareness - are usually the weakest. What's a higher rung you haven't tried yet?" - "Here, being wrong is allowed. The clown gets it wrong on purpose and keeps going. You can too, and you can sit this one out." - "What's the uncomfortable truth inside this issue?" - never "what's your childhood wound?" - "If your fix works, what pushes back?"

The settle and the closing minute: the shadow work is an opening, so it earns its close - the closing minute at every close, the way down and the close-return after the shadow door, and the closing minute at session scale on the last guided day. The shadow stays aimed at the problem, never at the self. The pace question sits at the close of week 2, two clear weeks before the shadow door, and again at the harvest.

Watch-fors (binding): aim shadow and inner-child work at the shadow of the *problem*, never a forced excavation of the self, because the shadow of a problem can be said in a room; the shadow of a self already has a home, the Log, and a room is not where a teenager is asked to open it. Opt-out always; the shadow comes last, lightest touch, because the two doors before it build the play that makes the third survivable. This long session runs through late winter - lighter-scope the deep days, lean on the once-weekly pivot (a deep block that has to move because of a hard day in the guide's own home is recoverable next week), protect your own fallow, and re-thread after any break. "The honest finding is that this problem is bigger than one year" is real - name it without shame. This session ends into a break two weeks after the shadow door: say aloud who is reachable across it.

What you'll need: the ladder of levers as a simple visual and as four plain sentences in order; improv and clowning prompts, chosen so every learner plays as built - clowning lives in the voice, the face, and the hands as much as the feet; the shadow question framed carefully (of the problem, opt-out); prototyping materials; the "what pushes back?" prompt.

Session 6 - Hands to Work (six weeks, Feb 19 - Mar 29)

What it's for: Act, for real, with real people - choosing how you serve, designing the work *with* the people who have the problem, and doing something that actually leaves them better off.

For the learner: This is where you act. You choose how you serve from five ways - direct help, advocacy, giving, building, or teaching - because chosen service teaches something assigned service can't. The core skill is designing with the people who have the problem, not for them. You talk to real, affected humans, and you let them shape the work.

Three honest things. Your project cannot start until a real person who has the problem says yes to it, and they can say stop at any point; that is their right and not a verdict on you, and the wait between the asking and the yes is the work, not a gap before it. The honest answer at the end may be "this did not serve us," and there is a calm, named way to make it right, because landing wrong is part of real work, not failing at it. A project that stopped because the people said stop is a whole harvest. And some of the people you work with may be having a very hard time. The guide stays close for that, and a situation heavier than the support around it is one we do not send you into. At the end, the people you worked with say whether it served them. That is their word about the work, not a grade on you. What it did in you is a separate question, and it's yours.

The flow:

Weeks 22-27 · Feb 19 - Mar 29 · off: Mon Feb 19, Presidents Day (the session's first day)

Week 1 - choose your mode (open, re-thread). - **Mon (your own):** core; which mode of serving fits you and your problem? Log. Check-in. - **Tue (lighter guide day):** the re-thread first, short; Impossible Question; the service-choice menu presented - direct service, advocacy, philanthropy, building, teaching; each learner chooses. - **Wed (your own):** core; plan your action; Log. Check-in. - **Thu (deep guide day):** empathy as the core skill; design *with*, never *for*; who are the real people with this problem? Bridge: invite one of them (not just interview) - ask whether this should happen, and let them shape it. - **Fri:** fallow.

Week 2 - design with (gather). Between the invitation and the yes there is a wait, and the wait is the work. A person deciding whether to let you in is doing the thing this session is about, and "they haven't answered" or "they said no" is a true place to be standing in the third week, not a week behind. - **Mon (your own):** core; talk to a real, affected person, if they have said yes; Log. Check-in. - **Tue (lighter guide day):** Impossible Question; service prep or building in company. - **Wed (your own):** core; shape your action from what real people told you; Log. Check-in. - **Thu (deep guide day):** design-with in practice; adjust your plan to the people, not your assumptions. Bridge: begin the real action. - **Fri:** fallow.

Weeks 3-5 - carry out the project, with real people (apply). Each week the same shape, and at the close of week 4, Thu Mar 15, the pace question: - **Mon / Wed (your own):** carry out the service, philanthropy, building, or teaching project, with real people; core; Log; check-in. - **Tue (lighter guide day):** Impossible Question; hands-on project work or service expeditions in company. - **Thu (deep guide day):** reflect on what's happening in the real action; iterate; hold anything heavy (hold, don't treat). Bridge: the next real step. - **Fri:** fallow.

Week 6 - a real action taken (harvest). - **Mon (your own):** core; finish and consolidate your action; Log. Check-in. - **Tue (lighter guide day):** Impossible Question; share what you did and what happened. - **Wed (your own):** core; reflect - did it leave people better off? Log. Check-in. - **Thu (deep guide day, harvest):** a real action taken, with real people, or honestly not yet, plus the reflection ("did this serve them, as they tell it? And, separately, what did it do in me?"). Voluntary share. Ask the pace question. Then the join with the Call to Action, so the April break is dwell time: the Problem / Stakes / Story / Ask card goes on the table and is read aloud once; the four ways of being seen are named as equal; and any community story a learner may want in their talk gets its yes asked for now, while the relationship is live, never retrofitted in the last week. Run the closing minute at session scale, Thu Mar 29, and say aloud who is reachable over the break. Bridge into Session 7: "You did the work. Now: tell a room what's worth solving. Here's the shape a Call takes, and the four ways you can give it; carry them over the break. Nothing is due." - **Fri:** fallow, closes Session 6.

Things to say: - "Design *with* the people who have the problem, never *for* them." - "Invite them, don't just interview them. Ask whether this should even happen, and let them shape it." - "Did this serve *you*?" - the community answers this, not the learner. - "If it landed wrong, we have a calm way to make it right. Repair is part of the service, not its failure."

The settle and the closing minute: real-people service can land heavy - carry the closing minute and the way down; route anything heavier than coaching to real support. Re-thread on the first guide day back after the break.

Watch-fors (the community-standing gate, binding): no project touches real people until a named community member is invited and agrees - to the project, its terms, and a way to say "stop." Name where the benefit flows up front (if the honest answer is "they're part of my learning project," that's the savior trap, caught early). The harvest sits with the community's verdict, not the learner's guess. A repair clause is the same promise as an honored empty harvest: landing wrong is not failing. Affected voices lead early, not at the last minute. No one's story enters the final talk without their consent. Do not send a learner into a situation heavier than the support around them - match the mode to readiness; stay close; service should stretch, not wound. Service expeditions are off-site; plan coverage per outing. Any work with people who are easily harmed gets a real adult's support, and so does the graceful ending of any community relationship.

What you'll need: the service-choice menu; the Problem / Stakes / Story / Ask card, for the harvest day; named community members invited and agreed before real people are touched; the benefit-flow and repair-clause conversations ready; off-site logistics and coverage; a partner adult where the situation calls for one.

Session 7 - The Call to Action (four weeks, Apr 9 - May 3, the year's harvest)

What it's for: Make a room care - stand up and make the case for a problem worth solving, with vulnerability as the persuasive force, and close the year back inside yourself before it ends.

For the learner: This is the harvest. You may make a talk: here is a problem worth solving, here is why it got to me, here is what I did and learned, here is what I'm asking of you. It is advocacy, not a sales pitch; honesty is what makes a room listen, more than polish, and you choose how much of yourself goes in. You choose who hears it, and you know all the choices now rather than in the last week. Four ways, equal, not one main road and three exits: the full room, with families

there; the tribe only; one person you choose; or a recorded or written form that you present, or that the guide or a person you choose presents for you while you sit with your people, or while you do not. Nobody will ever have to ask for one of these; all four are offered to everyone, the same way. The feast is in the last week, in the evening, and the last morning after it is the year's close, yours and the guide's together. A talk that says "here is why this was harder than I thought, and here is the smaller thing I'm asking" is a whole talk. "I have nothing to ask a room for yet" is a whole harvest.

The room that day is your people - families, the tribe, whoever you invite - and the tribe is your people if no one else comes, honored equally and never as consolation. It is a feast, not a judged presentation. The studio provides the base of the meal; bringing a dish is never required and nobody will know who did. You do not have to eat. There is a named place to step out to that night, and you do not owe anyone a reason. Two rules we hold for you. If your talk carries another person's story, you need their yes before it goes in; a community's pain is never your material without it. And afterwards people will want to ask about your talk. You do not have to answer any question, from anyone, including an adult who means well. "I'd rather not say" is complete, and the guide backs you in the room. The tribe also gives its chorus Call for the shared problem: the whole group saying together what you chose together, in a shape the group decides in rehearsal. If you argued against the shared problem and the room went the other way, you can stand in the chorus, stand with it silently, or sit it out. Before the feast, one question back to yourself: what came back changed in you? Then we eat.

The flow:

Weeks 28-31 · Apr 9 - May 3 · the session break falls before this session (Apr 2-5), not inside it

Week 1 - what a Call to Action is (open, re-thread). - **Mon (your own):** core; the Problem / Stakes / Story / Ask card from the last harvest in hand; what's the one thing you'd ask a room to do? Log. Check-in. - **Tue (lighter guide day):** re-thread first. Then the Impossible Question; what a Call to Action is - advocacy versus a sales pitch; the four shapes named again as equal, so the choice stays open the whole session. Anyone still choosing a shape is choosing, not behind. - **Wed (your own):** core; draft your Problem and your Ask; Log. Check-in. - **Thu (deep guide day):** what makes a room *care*? Honesty over polish; the story under the argument; where an arc lands and where it loses the room. Bridge: find your story, and write your Stakes. - **Fri:** fallow.

Week 2 - Problem, Stakes, Story, Ask, and the chorus (deepen). - **Mon (your own):** core; write your Stakes (why it matters, to whom) and your Story (why it got to *you*, what you did); Log. Check-in. - **Tue (lighter guide day):** Impossible Question; story-craft games - how an ordinary

experience becomes a story that moves people. Then the tribe builds the chorus Call for the Commons Problem together: what we chose, and what we ask, in a shape the group decides. A *we*, not five solos. A learner who argued the other way in the autumn chooses now whether to stand in it, stand with it silently, or sit it out, and can change their mind up to the night. - **Wed (your own):** core; a full first draft, in the form your talk takes; Log. Check-in. - **Thu (deep guide day):** shape the whole arc - Problem, Stakes, Story, Ask; share a passage (voluntary, aloud or in the form the talk takes; an offer, never a round); revision as care. Ask the pace question here, with two weeks left to act on the answer. Bridge: build it. - **Fri:** fallow.

Week 3 - build, then the dry run (apply). - **Mon (your own):** core; build and revise the talk; Log. Check-in. - **Tue (lighter guide day):** Impossible Question; talk-building and low-stakes delivery practice in company; the chorus run once. Confirm each learner's chosen shape in the walk-in, one to one, so choosing one person is never announced to the room. The four were on the table from the last harvest; this is the week the choice is made real, not first offered. - **Wed (your own):** core; last revisions; Log. Check-in. - **Thu (deep guide day):** the dry run, in the shape each learner chose - the tribe for those who chose it, with the one chosen person or the guide for those who did not. Each is the same dry run: the rehearsal, not a thing that precedes one. Hold nerves warmly; honesty is the force. What they said is the point, not how the room reacts. Bridge: rest. Nothing is built between the dry run and the feast. - **Fri:** fallow.

Week 4 - the Call to Action, the feast, and the year-close (harvest). - **Mon (your own):** core; final touches; rest. Check-in. - **Tue (lighter guide day):** the last Impossible Question of the year, then set the room together; last nerves held; the exit ramp named for the feast room and shown before anyone arrives. At the close of the morning, the turn back inward: "Having gone out to the world's problem, what came back changed in you?" - **The feast, Tuesday or Wednesday evening** (the guide's call, by their own day-shape; never the last Thursday): the Call to Action and feast, a real audience, families and the tribe. Each learner makes their case, as much and in whatever shape they choose, and the tribe gives the chorus Call for the Commons Problem; standing in it is offered, not required, and a learner who sits it out is still inside the *we*. Advocacy, or a Call to Repair, never a judged presentation; the tribe cheers each other. Being seen is a gift, never a demand. - **Wed (your own):** the interval, named as one: nothing asked back, nothing handed in. Core if you want it, rest if you need it. The noon check-in as always. - **Thu (deep guide day), the year-close:** after the feast has had its night, the three acts (Part 4): the co-authoring close with the whole short record on the table unasked, the Log handoff, the last re-ask, and the closing minute at year scale in its fixed words. Say aloud who is reachable over Open Waters and the summer, and that you are not. Bridge into the final year. - **Fri:** fallow, closes Session 7. Then Open Waters.

Things to say: - "This is advocacy, not a sales pitch. Honesty is what makes a room listen, more than polish. You choose how much of yourself goes in." - "Is this your Ask, or theirs? Whose voice are you carrying to this room?" - "Here is what I learned about why this is hard, and here is the smaller, truer ask" - a whole talk. Say so plainly; don't rank it above or below the others. - A Call to Repair: "Here is what I owe, here is who leads this, here is how you join *them*." - "The room will clap. That's fine, and it's not the point. What you said is the point." - Before the harvest, the turn back inward: "Having gone out to the world's problem, what came back changed in you?"

The settle and the closing minute: the Call to Action is a public harvest - an opening in front of other people - so it gets its private re-crossing afterward, the closing minute at year scale, in its fixed words, on the year-close day (see Part 4). Add the turn back inward at the close of the feast morning, the last ordinary guided morning before the room opens outward.

Watch-fors: being seen is invitational - depth is never a performance requirement. Offer the other three shapes as real roads, not as "share less." Name and hold the learner with no family in the room: the tribe is your people, a chosen witness is honored equally, never a consolation. Advocacy, not a stage performance - what they said is the point, not the applause; never coach for the room's reaction over the learner's conviction. No one's story enters the talk without their consent - a community's pain must never become the learner's persuasive story without that person's yes. Do not let the Wednesday between the feast and the year-close fill, and do not seat the year-close on the feast's last hour.

What you'll need: the Problem / Stakes / Story / Ask card, on the table at Session 6's harvest and read aloud there and again in week 1; the chorus Call's shape, decided by the tribe in week 2; story-craft prompts; a warm real audience arranged and told they are witnesses, not judges; each learner's chosen shape confirmed one to one; any recorded shape playable to the room with its transcript; consent secured for any story that touches another person, asked in Session 6 while the relationship is live, never retrofitted in the last week; the feast planned like a real event with the inclusion floor (base provided, presence not consumption, allergen-safe, no cover charge); the exit ramp named for the feast room; the co-authoring review structure; the Log handoff.

Part 4 - Closing the year

The Call to Action harvest

The year's harvest is the Call to Action and the feast at the end of Session 7. Each learner makes their case in the shape they chose, and the tribe raises the chorus Call for the shared Commons Problem they argued into being back in Session 4. This is a celebration, not a judged event. The guide holds what is true over what gets applause. Being seen is a gift, never a demand, and the talk that found only part of the answer - "here is what I learned about why this is hard, and here is the smaller, truer ask" - is held up as a whole talk, the one that understands how systems work, never put up with as an empty harvest.

The turn back inward

Before the year closes, add the small return beat. The Forge's arc runs from the self outward to the world; left there, it hands the learner back only the world's change and leaves the coming-back-to-yourself to the final year. So close it back, before the feast: "Having gone out to the world's problem, what came back changed in you?" The middle year closes its own loop. This is a thing the guide says about the year, the way Origin says "it's allowed to be a little tender." It is not a second closing minute.

The year-close

On the last guided day, after the feast has had its own night, three acts. First, a co-authoring close: the learner reviews the year's design *with* the guide, the design named not hidden - "here's how The Forge was built, and why; tell me what to change for the final year." The learner's call on their own year, never a feedback form, and declinable like every other quest. Alongside it, put the whole short record of them on the table, unasked: attendance, pace, credit plan, any safety note. Second, the Captain's Log ownership handoff: the Log is theirs; it goes

where they say - home, or back to the one place here only they open for next year - and no copy is kept. That is the same whatever form the Log took: if any of it lives on a studio device or in a scribe's hand, it goes to the learner and nothing stays behind. Third, the closing minute at the whole year's scale, in its fixed words. It is a naming, not a new ceremony; the practice they have run all year, put in their own hand at the year's scale:

> SAY
>
> "Before the next year opens, take your closing minute at the whole year's scale. What did you meet this year? What do you carry back? What's different in you now - even a little? 'I don't know yet' is a real answer."

That is what brings a learner back from standing in front of a room to being themselves. Then a real fallow stretch before the next year opens, and the fallow day stays empty; nothing is seated on it. Never start a new opening on a body still buzzing from the feast.

The tail of the year: Open Waters

The flex tail runs May 7 to May 24, the three weeks after Session 7 closes on May 3. It is light structure, not a void, and it is not an eighth session. Four things live there. Credit close-out, for anyone finishing the year's plan, on their own days as all year. Project finishing, because a prototype that was real in March is allowed to be finished in May, and allowed to stay unfinished. The relay handed on: this is where what you built with real people goes to whoever carries it next - back to the community member who said yes, to the tribe who comes after you, or to nobody, which is a true handoff too - and where that relationship ends well, with the thank-you said and the repair clause honoured if it was ever called on; a Call to Repair's "who leads this" is made good here, not only announced from a stage. The tribe's shared problem is passed the same way: what the chorus asked for is left where the next group can find it, in the room's own words, and the next group is free to leave it there. And rest, which is a legitimate use of all three weeks. Nothing the year did not finish is finished here; what a shorter session let go, it let go. Which mornings are guided in the tail is said before it starts, so nobody arrives to an empty room, and no re-thread opens it: the year-scale closing minute already closed the year, and a re-thread would reopen what the learner closed. On the last guided day, Thu May 24, say the summer's break words: the one adult is reachable all summer, 988 never closes, the guide is not reachable, the pathway stays live. Name it to families as intentional: flex plus fallow, not "we'll figure it out."

Some learners finish the Launch Pad at the end of this year. Each of them gets their own leaving rite, the Launch, in whichever year they leave from, because the end of their own line is the true end. It sits inside Open Waters, in the third week, on a day set with the learner and their circle and never the last day, because the last day is when the calendar ends and a crossing is not hurried by a calendar. It carries the same condition every Launch does: it waits until the Growth Record export is real, and that is checked in the second week, not on the day. The Helm's book carries the rite in full.

Then the bridge into the final year: "You found what's worth solving and acted on it. Next: what do you do when there is no easy answer?"

"We evoke - we never extract." - and that includes the guide, who chose the sustainable shape, and everyone in the room.